MERCY'S ANATOMY

Season 2, Episode 5

"Choose"

Episode 2x05. The counterpart of *Grey's Anatomy* 2x05. Narrator: Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock

In-story dates: Tuesday, October 11, 2005, 5:31 AM through 11:52 PM

Script: Cold Open + 5 Acts + Tag. 40 scenes. Standard: MA-009

Depends on MA-001 through MA-011 and episodes 1x01-2x04

EPISODE PDF PACKAGE (MA-009 §6): 1. Title page and cast (with ages on Tuesday, October 11, 2005). 2. Script. 3. Media Companion. 4. Continuity Sheet.

Cast in Order of Appearance (Ages on Tuesday, October 11, 2005)

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Dr. Esther Smilley	Surgical Intern	Sep 20, 1979	26
Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock	Surgical Intern (narrator)	Jan 5, 1979	26
Dr. Harmony Divine	Surgical Intern	Jun 19, 1979	26
Harriet Baker-Fenwick	Amond's mother	Oct 5, 1952	53
Dr. Raven Ellison	Surgical Intern	Dec 3, 1979	25
Dr. Elxa Bullock	Surgical Resident (23 weeks pregnant)	Aug 29, 1977	28
Dr. Arianna Cummings	Surgical Intern	Oct 25, 1979	25
Nikki Chambers (new)	Patient: CIPA, open forearm fracture	Aug 2, 1998	7
LaTonya Chambers (new)	Nikki's mother; school bus driver	Jan 15, 1974	31
Dr. Isaiah Crump	Chief of Pediatric Surgery	Mar 11, 1944	61
Dr. Camille Toussaint	Orthopedic Resident (PGY-3)	Jul 21, 1976	29
Dr. Natasha Donohue	Chief of Surgery	Jun 2, 1958	47
Rev. Isaac Ashworth (new)	QGH trustee; pastor, Greater Bethel Baptist	Mar 30, 1937	68
Dorian Batiste	Bridge Fund patient	Feb 15, 1997	8
Dr. Clayton Hartwell	Fetal Surgeon; Esther's husband	Mar 3, 1971	34
Nurse Gloria Pettiford	Head ER Nurse	Apr 14, 1952	53
Dr. Amond Baker	Surgical Intern (on medical leave)	Feb 10, 1979	26
Dr. Solomon Fenwick	Amond's stepfather	Mar 21, 1948	57
Dr. Leland Graves	Chief of Neurosurgery; hearing chair	Apr 18, 1953	52
Dr. Marlene Fisk	Director, Employee Health; hearing panel	Oct 3, 1947	58
Franklin Bassett, Esq.	General Counsel; hearing panel	Oct 28, 1958	46
Dr. Bryce Kennerly	Surgical Intern (hearing respondent)	Jun 11, 1978	27
Dr. Horace Whitlow	Chief of Medicine	Sep 19, 1949	56
Dr. Robert Bullock	Chief of Cardiothoracic Surgery	Feb 10, 1956	49
Booker Haines	Clinic patient: post-MVD	May 16, 1941	64
Mae Haines	Booker's wife	Feb 8, 1943	62
Odile Lemieux	Curtis's mother	Mar 19, 1936	69
Curtis Lemieux	Former patient: heart transplant	Apr 9, 1961	44
Bernadette 'Bernie' Watkins	Executive Assistant to the Chief	Jun 6, 1950	55
Lamont 'Monty' Gaines	Owner, Monty's on Jackson (43 since Oct 10)	Oct 10, 1962	43

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Raymond 'Big Ray' Toles	Chief of Security	Jan 1, 1960	45
Russell Jeffries	Elxa's husband	Apr 3, 1975	30

Also appearing: Rochelle Batiste, Bridge Fund families, a union representative, an OR team, Kendra Wallace, Deb Lyons, Tee Rollins, Andre Fontaine and Monty's party guests. Mentioned: Victor Donohue, Judge Kittredge, Dr. Greenidge, Malcolm Sloan, Simone Pettigrew (Collegiate, 1990s), Yvonne (Monty, 1987), and a CIPA family network run by a mother in Ohio.

COLD OPEN

1 INT. THE CLARENCE - CABIN - DAWN
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 5:31 AM

The boat is dry again, mostly. Damp towels hang from every hook. The bilge pump clicks. Esther (26) sits at the galley table in a sweater, the calendar face up again in front of her. Twenty-nine red X's. She uncaps the red pen. Over October 11 she doesn't draw an X. She draws a circle.

Pinned to the wall beside her: Dr. Greenidge's card, with three lines on the back now: "Ask myself the question. Not him." / "Don't let the calendar decide. -D.P.H." / and a new one, in fresh ink: "Session 9. I know."

MARC (V.O.)
In medicine, you learn very fast that you don't get to choose most things.

She picks up her RAZR. Types.

> SMS, to MARC: "roof at 4? day 30. i want you to hear it from me first. like i promised."

Her thumb hovers. She sends it.

MARC (V.O.)
You don't choose your patients. You don't choose which ones live. You don't choose the hour you're born or what you're born into.

2 EXT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - STOOP - DAWN
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 5:40 AM

Drizzle. Marc (26), in running clothes, lacing his shoes on the stoop. His phone buzzes. He reads it. He sits very still with one shoe untied.

The door opens behind him. Harmony (26), in her bonnet, with two coffees. She sees his face. She sits down beside him.

HARMONY
(quietly)
Day thirty.

MARC
(holding up the phone)
Four o'clock. The roof.

Harmony hands him a coffee. He doesn't drink it.

HARMONY
(beat)
Are you going to run anyway?

MARC
(beat)
I'm going to run anyway.

HARMONY
(beat)
Marc. (beat) Whatever she says up there. (beat) Come home after.

He looks at her.

MARC (V.O.)
But every once in a while, you get to choose one thing.

He ties his shoe. Stands. Runs off down 49th Avenue into the rain. Harmony sits on the stoop holding two coffees.

MARC (V.O.)
And the hardest part is that somebody else gets to choose too.

END OF COLD OPEN

ACT ONE

3 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - KITCHEN - MORNING
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 6:02 AM

Harriet Baker-Fenwick (53) stands in the kitchen in her traveling suit, delivering instructions to Raven (25) and

Harmony as if briefing a military unit. A typed list is taped to the fridge. Solomon (57) loads suitcases by the front door.

HARRIET
(tapping the list)
Iron, morning and night, with orange juice, not milk. He'll tell you milk is fine. Milk is not fine. (beat) Walking, ten minutes, three times a day. He'll tell you he walked. Ask him where. (beat) No lifting. He will try to carry his own laundry. Take it from him. Physically.

RAVEN
(writing it all down)
Physically.

HARRIET
(to Harmony)
And you. The one who makes grits.

HARMONY
Yes, ma'am.

HARRIET
(beat, lower)
He'll say he's fine. (beat) He's been saying it since he was nine years old in the back of his father's car. (beat) Don't believe him, and don't tell him you don't believe him. Just feed him.

HARMONY
(quietly)
Yes, ma'am.

Harriet nods, satisfied. Then she glances out the kitchen window at Marc, running back up 49th Avenue in the rain.

HARRIET
(beat)
And that one. (beat) Arianna told Amond and Amond told me. Today's the day, isn't it?

Raven and Harmony exchange a look.

HARRIET
(picking up her handbag)
My mother used to say a woman who needs thirty days to decide already decided on day one. She just needed twenty-nine to be sure she could live with it.

4 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - THE BOARD - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 6:30 AM

The interns gather. Esther at her end of the Board. Marc at his. Today the six feet between them seem very small and very far. Everyone knows what day it is. Nobody says it.

Elxa (28), twenty-three weeks, reads assignments.

ELXA
Bullock: Crump and ortho in the Pit. A seven-year-old with congenital insensitivity to pain. She came in with a broken arm she didn't notice. (beat) Smilley: Graves. Clinic follow-ups this morning. Your trigeminal neuralgia's coming back for his check. (beat) Divine: ortho, with Dr. Toussaint.

Raven very quietly elbows Harmony. Harmony ignores her.

ELXA
Ellison, Cummings: general surgery, with me. (beat) And Kennerly's harassment hearing is at ten, in the twelfth-floor conference room. Smilley, Cummings, you're both called as witnesses. (beat) Don't be late. Don't be early. Don't punch anybody.

ARIANNA
(deadpan)
No promises.

As they scatter, Esther and Marc pass each other at the end of the Board. For one second they're shoulder to shoulder.

ESTHER
(very low)
Four.

MARC
(very low)
Four.

5 INT. PELL PAVILION - THE PIT - TRAUMA 2 - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 6:48 AM

NIKKI CHAMBERS (7), pigtails with pink barrettes, sits on the gurney swinging her legs and chattering happily. Her left forearm is badly deformed, the skin split over a jagged end of bone. A towel is wrapped around it, soaked through. She is completely, eerily calm.

Her mother, LATONYA CHAMBERS (31), a school bus driver in a reflective vest, stands beside her, gray with exhaustion. Marc, Dr. Isaiah Crump (61) and Dr. Camille Toussaint (29), the ortho resident, examine the arm. Harmony stands behind Camille.

NIKKI
(cheerfully, to Marc)
I fell off the monkey bars yesterday. At recess. (beat) I didn't cry.

LATONYA
(flat)
She didn't cry because she didn't feel it. (beat) She came home and ate dinner with it. I didn't see the blood till her bath.

CRUMP
(gently)
Congenital insensitivity to pain with anhidrosis. Diagnosed when?

LATONYA
Eighteen months. She chewed the tip of her tongue off cutting her first teeth. (beat) She doesn't sweat either. She gets fevers that don't break.

CAMILLE
(unwrapping the towel, wincing)
Open radius and ulna. Contaminated. Overnight in the wound. (to Nikki, bright) Baby, you broke your arm so good it came out to say hello.

NIKKI
(delighted)
It came out to say hello!

MARC
(checking her pulse)
Mrs. Chambers. Has she had a fever since yesterday?

LATONYA
(beat)
She was warm this morning. She's always warm. (beat) I gave her Tylenol and put her in the car.

Marc puts the back of his hand on Nikki's forehead. His face changes. He picks up the tympanic thermometer.

MARC
(reading it)
One-oh-four point one.

CRUMP
(beat)
Infection from the open fracture. And she can't sweat to cool down. (beat) OR for washout and fixation. But we cool her first. Now.

6 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - BRIDGE FUND PHARMACY - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 7:14 AM

A converted storage room on the ground floor, freshly painted, with a hand-lettered sign: "VICTOR DONOHUE FOUNDATION - PEDIATRIC CHRONIC CARE BRIDGE FUND - NO RECORDS REQUIRED." A short line of families: a Katrina mother with an inhaler prescription, a grandfather with a diabetic boy.

Natasha (47) walks in with REV. ISAAC ASHWORTH (68), pastor of Greater Bethel Baptist Church in St. Albans: tall, white-haired, in a black suit and a clerical collar, with the gentle, watchful eyes of a man who has buried more children than he can count.

NATASHA
This is it, Reverend. Two pharmacists, a social worker and a nurse. Open sixteen hours a day. (beat) Three hundred and twelve children served since September eighth.

REV. ASHWORTH
(looking at the line)
From the hurricane?

NATASHA
Some from the hurricane. Some from Jamaica Avenue. The fund doesn't ask.

At the counter, a small boy turns around. DORIAN BATISTE (8), holding a paper bag of insulin pens, with his aunt Rochelle. He sees Natasha.

DORIAN
(excited)
You're the Chief! (beat) Dr. Cummings said you're the Chief of the whole hospital.

NATASHA
(smiling)
I am. How's Beignet?

DORIAN
(to Rev. Ashworth, unprompted)
My dog was in a flood. In Gentilly. A foundation found him. They put him on a plane. (beat) My insulin was in the flood too. Now I get it here. For free. (beat) Are you a doctor?

REV. ASHWORTH
(beat, gently)
No, son. I'm a preacher.

DORIAN
(considering)
My grandma says preachers talk to God. (beat) Can you tell God thank you for the dog?

Rev. Ashworth looks at the boy for a long moment. Then he crouches down, eye level, knees cracking.

REV. ASHWORTH
(quietly)
I'll tell Him tonight, son. I promise.

Dorian beams and runs back to his aunt. Rev. Ashworth stands slowly. He doesn't look at Natasha.

REV. ASHWORTH
(quietly)
Dr. Donohue. I'm not going to tell you how I'll vote on the twentieth.

NATASHA
(evenly)
I wouldn't ask you to, Reverend.

REV. ASHWORTH
(beat)
Good. (beat) Because Horace Whitlow asked me yesterday. (beat) He didn't bring a little boy.

7 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - LABOR AND DELIVERY - CORRIDOR - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 7:41 AM

Clayton (34) comes out of Nadia Ellerbe's room with a chart. Esther, on her way to Graves's clinic, stops in front of him. The corridor is empty.

CLAYTON
(beat)
Es.

ESTHER
(quietly)
Day thirty.

CLAYTON
(beat)
I know what day it is. I've known since September eleventh.

Esther looks at him. His careful calm, and the fear underneath it.

ESTHER
(beat)
After Dr. Greenidge last night, I knew. (beat) I'm going to tell Marc first. At four. On the roof. (beat) I promised him he'd hear things from me first. (beat) Then I'll come find you.

A long beat. Clayton searches her face. She gives him nothing.

CLAYTON
(finally, quietly)
You're not going to tell me now.

ESTHER
(beat)
No.

CLAYTON
(beat)
Because it's no?

ESTHER
(beat)
Because I promised him first. (beat) That's all it means, Clayton. That's all I'm going to let it mean until four o'clock.

She walks away. Clayton stands in the corridor holding the chart, staring at nothing.

8 INT. PELL PAVILION - THE PIT - TRAUMA 2 - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 7:58 AM

Nikki lies on the gurney, packed in ice: bags in her armpits, at her groin, behind her neck. A cooling blanket hums beneath her. A fan blows a mist of water over her skin. She is suddenly quiet, glassy-eyed, her cheeks flushed scarlet. LaTonya holds her good hand. Marc watches the monitor. Crump checks her pupils.

MARC
(reading)
One-oh-five point four. (beat)
It's going up, not down.

CRUMP
(sharp)
The acetaminophen's useless. Her body can't dump heat. (beat) Cold saline, a liter, IV. Rectal probe. (beat) If she seizes, lorazepam, point one per kilo.

Nikki's eyes roll. Her small body stiffens.

LATONYA
(screaming)
Nikki! NIKKI!

Nikki begins to seize: a full tonic-clonic seizure, her body jerking against the ice packs. Marc grabs the lorazepam. Crump turns her on her side.

CRUMP
Lorazepam. Now.

MARC
(pushing it)
In.

The seizure goes on. Five seconds. Ten. Fifteen.

CRUMP
(very calm)
She's cooking from the inside, Dr. Bullock. (beat) The fever's not the infection anymore. It's the fever itself.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

9 INT. PELL PAVILION - THE PIT - TRAUMA 2 - CONTINUOUS
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 8:01 AM

The seizure stops. Nikki goes limp, breathing in deep, ragged gulps. Marc holds her on her side. Crump checks her airway. Gloria (53) runs in with two more bags of ice.

GLORIA
Ice. And the cold saline's at room temperature, so I put it in the freezer for ten minutes.

CRUMP
(dry)
Gloria, I'd marry you if I weren't already married.

GLORIA
(packing the ice)
You've said that since 1979, Isaiah.

MARC
(watching the monitor)
One-oh-four point nine. (beat) One-oh-four point six. (beat) It's coming down.

LaTonya sinks into the chair. She covers her face.

LATONYA
(muffled)
Seven years. (beat) Seven years I've checked her every night. Her feet, her hands, her mouth, her eyes. Looking for blood, because she won't tell me. She can't. (beat) I took one morning off. One morning. I gave her Tylenol and put her in the car. I just wanted one morning where she was a normal kid with a little fever.

Marc kneels beside the chair so he's at eye level with her.

MARC
(gently)
Mrs. Chambers. You brought her in. With an open fracture she couldn't feel and a fever she can't sweat out. (beat) You caught it. That's not a mistake. That's a mother.

LATONYA
(looking at him)
You don't understand. (beat) Pain is how children learn. "Don't touch the stove." "Don't jump off the roof." (beat) She doesn't have that. I have to be her pain. Every minute. For the rest of her life.

Marc has nothing to say to that. He takes her hand.

CRUMP
(quietly, watching from the head of the bed)
Ninety-nine degrees by the time we get her upstairs. Then Dr. Toussaint fixes her arm.

10 EXT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - FRONT STEPS - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 8:41 AM

A town car idles at the curb in the drizzle. Solomon loads the last suitcase into the trunk. Harriet stands on the top step under an umbrella, facing Amond, who stands in the doorway in a hoodie, one hand on the frame.

HARRIET
(crisp)
Iron with orange juice.

AMOND
I know, Mom.

HARRIET
Ten minutes, three times a day.

AMOND
I know.

HARRIET
(beat)
And you'll call me on Sundays.

AMOND
(beat)
Mom...

HARRIET
(sharp)
Sundays, Amond. Not "when you get a chance." Sundays. (beat) You call your mother on Sundays, or I get on a plane and alphabetize every spice in this house again.

A beat. Amond almost smiles.

AMOND
(beat)
Sundays.

Harriet nods. She turns to go. Then turns back, steps up and puts her gloved hand flat against her son's cheek. Just for a second.

HARRIET
(quietly, all the crispness gone)
Your father would have been so proud of you, it would have been unbearable. (beat) He'd have told everyone at the Lakers game.

Amond can't speak. Harriet takes her hand away, turns and walks down the steps to the car. Solomon holds the door for her. Before he gets in, he looks up at Amond.

AMOND
(finally, calling down)
Solomon. (beat) Thank you. For the photo.

SOLOMON
(beat, smiling)
Sundays, son. (beat) I'll pick up too, sometimes.

The car pulls away down 49th Avenue. Amond stands in the doorway long after it's gone.

11 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - TWELFTH FLOOR CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 10:00 AM

A long table. The Graduate Medical Education Committee hearing panel: DR. MARLENE FISK (58), Employee Health; Franklin Bassett (46), general counsel; and Dr. Leland Graves (52), chairing, stone-faced. Across from them: Kennerly, in a suit, with a union representative. In the back row, uninvited but within his rights as a department chief: Whitlow.

Esther sits in the witness chair. Arianna waits by the wall.

GRAVES
Dr. Smilley. In your own words.

ESTHER
(steady)
When I was twenty, my family needed money. My father had been killed in a robbery in 1987. My mother cleaned offices at night. My sisters needed braces. (beat) A hair-care company paid me four thousand dollars to stand in a photograph in a slip. (beat) Dr. Kennerly found that photograph online. He made about three hundred copies on the hospital copier and taped one to Lockwood's Lamp in the main lobby, where my patients' families walk past.

KENNERLY'S UNION REP
(smoothly)
Dr. Smilley, the image was publicly available. It was published in national magazines.

ESTHER
(turning to look at him)
So were my father's crime-scene photos, in the Boston Globe, in 1987. (beat) Would it have been funny to tape those to the lamp?

Silence. Fisk writes something. Bassett looks at his pen.

ESTHER
(back to the panel)
It wasn't a prank. A prank is something you'd do in front of the person. (beat) He did it at four in the morning, so he could watch from across the lobby as people saw it. (beat) That's all I have to say.

GRAVES
(beat)
Thank you, Dr. Smilley.

Whitlow, in the back row, stands.

WHITLOW
(pleasantly)
If the committee permits. Dr. Kennerly has spent the last week on my consult service. He's diligent. Respectful. (beat) Every institution should allow a young man to learn from a single mistake.

GRAVES
(without looking at him)
Noted, Dr. Whitlow. (beat) This committee has heard from the Chief of Medicine, who was not asked to speak. (beat) Dr. Cummings. You're next.

Arianna walks to the witness chair. She passes Kennerly on the way. She doesn't look at him once.

12 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - OR 2 - VIEWING GALLERY - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 10:34 AM

Below, Robert (49) performs a mitral valve repair. The gallery is empty except for one figure in the back row, in jeans, a gray hoodie and a Queens Grace ID, sitting very still, notebook on his knee: Amond (26), seven days after surgery.

Robert glances up at the glass without stopping. He leans toward the intercom button with his elbow.

ROBERT
(over the intercom, mild)
Dr. Baker.

AMOND
(pressing the gallery intercom)
Good morning, sir.

ROBERT
(sewing)
You're on medical leave.

AMOND
I'm observing. (beat) Observing isn't working. Observing is sitting. Dr. Lowery said I could sit.

ROBERT
(beat)
Your mother left for LAX at nine.

AMOND
(beat)
She did.

ROBERT
(beat, still sewing)
And you called a car service at nine-fifteen.

AMOND
(beat)
Big Ray told you.

ROBERT
(dry)
Big Ray tells me everything, Dr. Baker. (beat) It's a P2 prolapse. Triangular resection. Watch closely, because it's the last thing you'll see in here for two weeks. (beat) Then go home.

Amond leans forward and watches with fierce, hungry eyes. On the notebook on his knee: a detailed diagram of the mitral valve, labeled, from memory.

13 INT. PELL PAVILION - THE PIT - NURSES' STATION - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 11:05 AM

Rain streaks the Pit's windows. Raven writes orders. Arianna comes back from the hearing, drops into the chair beside her and stares at the rain.

ARIANNA
(flat)
Still raining.

RAVEN
(not looking up)
I saw.

ARIANNA
The forecast said Monday. (beat)
It's Tuesday.

RAVEN
(beat)
Then the forecast lied.

ARIANNA
(turning to her)
Ellison. (beat) Weather's not a reason.

RAVEN
(finally looking at her)
It's my reason. (beat) I said what I said.

A beat. Arianna studies her. Then something in her face relaxes, almost a smile.

ARIANNA
(beat)
How was the hearing, you didn't ask.

RAVEN
(immediately)
How was the hearing?

ARIANNA
(beat)
Smilley went first. She compared Kennerly's copies to her father's crime-scene photos in the Globe. (beat) Graves almost smiled. (beat) I've never seen Graves almost smile.

RAVEN
(impressed)
What did you say?

ARIANNA
(shrugging)
I made the first twelve copies. I said that. Then I said I'd regretted it for three months. (beat) I said Kennerly made three hundred and still hasn't. (beat) Then Whitlow stood up and called him "diligent." (beat) In front of Graves.

RAVEN
(beat)
Why does Whitlow care about Kennerly?

ARIANNA
(beat, watching the rain)
That's what I'd like to know.

14 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - OR 5 - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 11:40 AM

Nikki on the table, cooled to 99.1, under general anesthesia. Her left forearm is open. Camille operates. Harmony assists. Crump watches from the head of the table. Marc is on the other side.

CAMILLE
Irrigating. Six liters, pulse lavage. (beat) Debriding the dead stuff. (beat) Choir, retract the brachioradialis.

Harmony retracts. Camille works.

HARMONY
(quietly)
Dr. Toussaint. (beat) Does she need anesthesia? If she can't feel pain?

CAMILLE
(glancing at Crump)
Good question. Isaiah?

CRUMP
(from the head of the table)
She can't feel pain, Dr. Divine. Her body still responds to injury: heart rate, blood pressure, stress hormones. And she can still feel touch and pressure. (beat) We put her to sleep so her body doesn't fight what we're doing. (beat) Nobody should be awake for this. Even someone who can't feel it.

Camille fixes the radius with a plate and screws, fast and precise.

CAMILLE
(screwing)
Plate on the radius. Ulna gets an intramedullary rod. (beat, to Harmony, lightly) So, Choir. Friday.

Marc, across the table, glances up.

HARMONY
(flustered, retracting)
Dr. Toussaint, we're in an OR.

CAMILLE
I've asked women out in worse places. (beat) There's a Creole place in Fort Greene that does a gumbo almost as good as my Tante Josette's. (beat) Friday. Seven-thirty.

Marc looks from Camille to Harmony and back. He didn't know. Harmony doesn't look at him.

HARMONY
(very quietly)
I'm... thinking about it.

CAMILLE
(driving the last screw)
Good. Think hard, Choir. (beat) Rod.

15 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - ON-CALL ROOM 2 - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 12:28 PM

Elxa, on the bottom bunk with her feet on three pillows, eats a turkey sandwich. Marc sits on the floor against the bunk, still in OR scrubs.

ELXA
(chewing)
Four o'clock.

MARC
Four o'clock.

ELXA
(beat)
What are you going to say?

MARC
(beat)
Nothing. I'm going to listen. (beat) She asked for thirty days. It's her decision. She promised I'd hear it first. I'm going to go up there and hear it.

ELXA
(putting down the sandwich)
Liar.

Marc looks up at her.

ELXA
(beat)
You've had that face since the Board. The face you made in tenth grade before you asked Simone Pettigrew to the Collegiate spring formal. (beat) You're going to say something.

MARC
(long beat)
I told her "enough." (beat) I meant it. I gave her thirty days with nothing from me in them. (beat) And Granddaddy told me Saturday night, in the back of his car, that "not yet" is sometimes the polite word for "no." (beat) If I go up there and only listen, El... (beat) Then I never asked. (beat) And I'll spend my whole life not knowing if she'd have picked me if I'd asked.

Elxa looks at her little brother for a long time.

ELXA
(quietly)
Then ask. (beat) But don't do it like a Bullock. (beat) Don't do it like a speech. Daddy gives speeches. Mama gives rulings. Granddaddy gives billion-dollar funds. (beat) Do it like you. (beat) The guy who says "yes, ma'am" to the nurses and means it.

MARC
(beat)
What if she says no?

ELXA
(picking the sandwich back up)
Then she says no to the best man I know. (beat) And you'll still be him tomorrow.

16 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CHIEF OF MEDICINE'S OFFICE - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 1:12 PM

Whitlow at his desk. Kennerly stands in front of it, still in his hearing suit, sullen.

KENNERLY
Probation. Sensitivity training. A letter in my file. (beat) Graves wouldn't even look at me.

WHITLOW
(pleasantly)
You kept your job, Dr. Kennerly. (beat) Graves wanted you gone. I made sure the committee heard a different voice.

KENNERLY
(beat)
Thank you, sir.

WHITLOW
(opening a drawer)
You can thank me with a little more homework. (beat) The bus driver's grandson. Bullock. (beat) Where did he go to high school?

KENNERLY
(confused)
I don't know. D.C.? Why?

WHITLOW
(beat)
Because Dr. Robert Bullock moved his family to Manhattan in 1993, when his wife became Chief of Obstetrics here. (beat) If the intern is his son, he'd have been fourteen. (beat) He'd have gone to high school here. In New York.

He pulls out a fat, leather-bound book with gold lettering on the spine and sets it on the desk. Kennerly reads the spine.

KENNERLY
(reading)
"Collegiate School. The Yearbook. 1997."

WHITLOW
(opening it)
My godson graduated from Collegiate in 1998. (beat) He kept his older brother's yearbook from the year before.

He turns pages: senior portraits, boys in blazers and ties. He stops. He turns the book around so Kennerly can see it.

A senior portrait. A tall, grinning eighteen-year-old with dimples, in a navy blazer and tie. Under it: "MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK. Varsity Basketball (Capt.). Debate. Model U.N. 'Bullock is a common name.' -- Princeton? Howard.

Definitely Howard."

Kennerly stares at it.

KENNERLY
(slowly)
Collegiate's like eighteen thousand dollars a year.

WHITLOW
(closing the book, softly)
Seventeen thousand nine hundred, in 1997. (beat) Not bad for a bus driver's grandson.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

17 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - PEDIATRIC RECOVERY - BED 3 - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 1:40 PM

Nikki, waking up, her left arm in a splint, her temperature 99.0 on the monitor, sleepy and cheerful. LaTonya sits beside her. Marc checks the dressing.

NIKKI
(groggy, bright)
Did they fix it?

MARC
They fixed it. A metal plate and a rod. (beat) You're going to set off metal detectors at the airport.

NIKKI
(delighted)
Like a robot!

MARC
Like a robot.

Nikki looks at her mother. Then back at Marc.

NIKKI
(curious)
Mommy says you're sad today.

LaTonya looks mortified. Marc glances at her. She shrugs: she noticed.

MARC
(beat, honest)
A little.

NIKKI
(thinking about it)
Does it hurt? (beat) Being sad?

Marc stops what he's doing.

MARC
(quietly)
Yeah, Nikki. It hurts.

NIKKI
(beat, matter of fact)
Lucky.

LaTonya closes her eyes. Marc looks at the little girl who has never felt a single thing hurt in her life.

NIKKI
(yawning)
Mommy says if I could feel it, I'd know to stop before I break. (beat) You can feel it. So you know when to stop.

She falls back asleep. Marc stands there for a long moment.

LATONYA
(quietly)
She says that to everybody. She learned it from me. (beat) It's the only way I know to explain it to her.

MARC
(beat)
It's a good way, Mrs. Chambers.

18 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - NEUROSURGERY CLINIC - EXAM ROOM 2 - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 2:05 PM

Booker Haines (64), eight days after microvascular decompression, sits on the exam table with a healed scar behind his ear and a clean-shaven face. Both sides. Mae (62) sits beside him, holding his hand. Esther checks his facial sensation with a cotton swab.

ESTHER
Light touch on the right cheek?

BOOKER
(grinning)
Feels like a cotton swab. (beat)
Just a cotton swab. Nothing else.

ESTHER
(smiling)
No lightning?

BOOKER
No lightning. Eight days. (beat)
I shaved both sides on Sunday,
Doctor. First time since 1999.
(beat) Cut myself twice. Didn't
care.

Mae leans over and kisses him on the right cheek. Right on the spot where, for twelve years, she couldn't. Booker closes his eyes.

MAE
(to Esther, eyes
shining)
My granddaughter kissed him
goodnight on Sunday. (beat) He
didn't scream. (beat) She asked
her mother if Granddaddy was
fixed.

BOOKER
(to Esther)
You remember what I said to you
before the surgery?

ESTHER
(beat)
"Don't ever wait twelve years on
anything."

BOOKER
(nodding)
And did you listen?

Esther looks at the old man and his wife, holding hands on the exam table.

ESTHER
(quietly)
I waited thirty days, Mr. Haines.

BOOKER
(beat)
Thirty days is a lot better than twelve years, young lady. (beat) What did you decide?

ESTHER
(beat)
I'm telling him at four.

MAE
(gently)
Which him, baby?

Esther doesn't answer. She tosses the cotton swab in the trash.

19 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - LIVING ROOM - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 2:31 PM

Amond, sent home by Robert, lies on the fantastic couch, furious, reading a cardiac surgery journal. The doorbell rings. He gets up very slowly, one hand on his abdomen, and opens the door.

Odile Lemieux (69), in a church hat and a raincoat, holds a mason jar and a foil-wrapped plate. Behind her, Curtis Lemieux (44), discharged yesterday, his face round from steroids, a surgical mask on, holds his trombone case.

ODILE
(sweeping in)
Baby doctor. (beat) We heard you were alone in this big house.

AMOND
(stunned)
Mrs. Lemieux. (beat) Mr. Lemieux. You're immunosuppressed. You shouldn't be...

CURTIS
(through the mask, cheerful)
I'm wearing a mask. Dr. Bullock said fresh air and nobody coughing. (beat) Is anybody coughing?

AMOND
(beat)
No.

CURTIS
Then we're good. (holding up the trombone case) Mama said you need cheering up. (beat) I haven't played since August. My heart wasn't up to it. (beat) This one is.

Before Amond can protest, Curtis sits down on the fantastic couch, opens the case and lifts out a battered silver trombone. Odile goes straight to the kitchen as if she owns it. Harriet's labels are everywhere. Odile reads one ("TURMERIC - NOT CURRY POWDER") and snorts.

Curtis lifts the horn to his lips and plays "Just a Closer Walk with Thee," slow and rich and New Orleans, the sound filling the big empty house.

Amond sits down slowly in the armchair across from him. He closes his eyes. He lets it play.

20 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - STAIRWELL C - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 3:52 PM

Marc climbs the stairs toward the roof, two at a time, then slower. On the landing below the roof door, Harmony is sitting on the steps, waiting. She stands up when she sees him.

MARC
(stopping)
Double-O.

HARMONY
(beat)
I wasn't going to come up. (beat) I just wanted to see your face before you went through that door.

MARC
(beat)
Why?

HARMONY
(beat)
So I'd know what it looked like before. (beat) In case it looks different after.

Marc looks at her for a long moment. Something about the way she says it.

MARC
(beat)
Toussaint asked you out. In the OR.

HARMONY
(beat, looking at the stairs)
She did.

MARC
(gently)
Are you going?

HARMONY
(beat)
I don't know yet. (beat) I'll know after four.

She doesn't explain that. Marc doesn't ask her to. She reaches up and straightens the collar of his scrub top, the way you'd straighten a man's tie before church.

HARMONY
(quietly)
Go. (beat) Then come home.

21 EXT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - ROOFTOP - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 4:00 PM

The rain has thinned to mist. The East River is high and brown. Manhattan is hazy, half there. Esther stands at the railing in her white coat, arms crossed. The door opens. Marc comes out. He walks to the railing and stands three feet from her. Like the sofa. Like the dock.

ESTHER
(quietly)
You came.

MARC
You asked.

A long silence. Esther takes a breath.

ESTHER
Marc, I...

MARC
(gently)
Wait. (beat) Please. (beat) Let me say something first. And then you can say anything you want, and I'll listen, and I'll go.

Esther closes her mouth. She nods.

MARC
(beat)
I told you "enough" in the elevator. I meant it. I gave you thirty days with nothing from me in them. (beat) I didn't call. I didn't look. I held a hose on your boat in a nor'easter and didn't say a word, and I watched you get in a cab with him. (beat) I did all of that because I love you and it was your decision.

MARC
(beat)
And somebody very old and very wise told me on Saturday night that "not yet" is sometimes the polite word for "no." (beat) So I'm not going to stand here and say "not yet." (beat) I'm not going to stand here and just listen and then go home and spend the rest of my life wondering.

He turns to face her fully.

MARC
(quietly, simply)
So I'm asking. (beat) Choose me, Esther. (beat) Not because he hurt you. Not because I'm the safer thing, or the newer thing, or the thing that happened on a bad night at a bar. (beat) Choose me because I'm the one who told you the truth sober. Because I'm the one who'll tell you the truth every day for the rest of your life, even when it's the worst thing I've got. (beat) I want the big family. The crowded kitchen. The kids who'll grow up thinking their father was always this lucky. (beat) I want it with you. (beat) That's all. That's the whole speech. (beat) Choose me.

The mist drifts across the roof. Esther's eyes are full. She doesn't wipe them.

She looks at him for a long, long time.

ESTHER
(barely)
Marc. (beat) I'm going to try. (beat) With Clayton.

Marc doesn't move. His face doesn't change. That's how she knows how much it hurts.

ESTHER
(crying now, steady anyway)
Not thirty days. A real try. (beat) I made a vow, in front of my mother, in Oak Bluffs. I ran from it without ever finding out if I'm the kind of person who can stay. (beat) If I leave him now, without trying, I'll never know. (beat) And I'll bring that into everything after. Into you. Into whatever we'd be. (beat) I can't do that to you. You deserve somebody who isn't carrying a door she never closed.

MARC
(very quietly)
You slept with him. Saturday.

Esther closes her eyes.

ESTHER
(beat)
Yes. (beat) I'm telling you that too. First. (beat) Like I promised.

Marc nods slowly. He looks out at the river for a long moment.

MARC
(finally, barely)
Thank you. (beat) For telling me first.

ESTHER
(sobbing)
Marc...

MARC
(turning back to her, gently)
I asked. (beat) You answered. (beat) That's what we said we'd do.

He walks to the roof door. He opens it. He stops with his hand on it, his back to her.

MARC
(without turning around)
Be happy, Es. (beat) Please. (beat) Or come tell me if you're not.

The door closes behind him. Esther stands alone at the railing, where, five weeks ago, she said "I'm married" to the river.

END OF ACT THREE

ACT FOUR

22 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - STAIRWELL C - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 4:06 PM

Marc comes down the stairs from the roof slowly, one hand on the rail. Harmony is still on the landing. She stands up. She sees his face.

HARMONY
(barely)
I know.

MARC
(stopping two steps above her)
She's going to try. With him. (beat) A real try. (beat) She told me first. (beat) She kept her promise.

His voice is perfectly steady. His hand on the rail isn't.

HARMONY
(quietly)
Marc.

MARC
(beat)
I asked, Double-O. (beat) I didn't do it like a speech. I did it like me. (beat) And she said no.

Harmony climbs the two steps and puts her arms around him. He stands rigid for a second. Then he bends down, puts his forehead on her shoulder and holds on.

HARMONY
(into his shoulder)
You asked. (beat) That's the bravest thing I've ever seen anybody do.

MARC
(muffled)
It doesn't feel brave.

HARMONY
(beat, holding him tighter)
It never does when you're the one doing it.

23 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SUPPLY ROOM - SURGICAL FLOOR - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 4:12 PM

Esther sits on an overturned box between shelves of gauze and IV tubing, sobbing silently into her hands. The door opens. Gloria (53), on her way to grab saline, stops. She closes the door behind her.

GLORIA
(quietly)
Lord, baby.

She sits down on a box of Chux pads beside Esther. She doesn't touch her. She just sits.

ESTHER
(through tears)
I told him first. (beat) I chose and I told him first, like I promised, and it was the right thing, and I feel like I cut something out of myself with a dull knife.

GLORIA
(beat)
Right things usually feel like that. (beat) Wrong things feel good for about a week.

ESTHER
(laughing, wetly)
Is that a proverb?

GLORIA
(beat)
That's thirty years in an emergency room. (beat) And two husbands.

Esther looks at her.

GLORIA
(beat)
First one I left too fast. Second one I stayed with too long. (beat) Both times I thought I was choosing a man. (beat) I was choosing which version of me I could live with.

ESTHER
(barely)
Which one did you end up with?

GLORIA
(standing, picking up a box of saline)
Me, baby. I ended up with me. (beat) That's the only one you ever actually get to keep.

24 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - FETAL THERAPY OFFICE - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 4:31 PM

Clayton sits at his desk, not working, staring at a fetal echo on the light box without seeing it. A knock. Esther comes in, eyes red, composed. She closes the door. Clayton stands.

CLAYTON
(barely)
Es.

ESTHER
(beat)
I'm staying.

Clayton doesn't move.

ESTHER
(beat)
Not thirty more days. Not a trial. (beat) A real try, Clayton. The kind where we find out if we're still married or just still legally attached.

CLAYTON
(his voice breaking)
Es...

ESTHER
(holding up a hand)
Conditions. (beat) Dr. Greenidge, every week, as long as she says. (beat) No secrets. Not one. If Malcolm calls you, I know that day. If you're tempted, you tell me before you do anything about it. (beat) I keep my name at work. I'm Dr. Smilley here. (beat) And I don't move off the boat until I'm ready. Not because you asked. Because I'm ready.

CLAYTON
(beat, nodding)
Yes. (beat) All of it. Yes.

A long silence. Clayton comes around the desk. He stops in front of her. He doesn't touch her.

CLAYTON
(quietly)
You told him first.

ESTHER
(beat)
I promised him.

CLAYTON
(beat)
What did he say?

ESTHER
(looking past him, at the light box, at the tiny heart on the echo)
He asked me to choose him. (beat) And then he thanked me for telling him first. (beat) And then he told me to be happy. Or to come tell him if I'm not.

Clayton closes his eyes.

CLAYTON
(barely)
He's a better man than me, Es.

ESTHER
(beat, looking at him)
I know. (beat) That's not what this is about.

She steps forward and puts her forehead against his chest. He puts his arms around her, very carefully, like a man holding something he's broken once and doesn't trust himself with.

25 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - FETAL THERAPY CORRIDOR - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 4:39 PM

Marc comes around the corner and nearly walks into Clayton, who is coming out of his office. They both stop. A long beat in the empty corridor.

CLAYTON
(quietly)
Bullock.

MARC
(evenly)
Dr. Hartwell.

CLAYTON
(beat)
She told me. (beat) She said she told you first.

MARC
(beat)
She did.

CLAYTON
(beat, with difficulty)
I'm sorry.

MARC
(beat)
Don't be. (beat) Be good to her.

CLAYTON
(beat)
I intend to.

MARC
(meeting his eyes, steady, not a threat, a promise)
Then you and I won't ever have a problem.

He walks on. Clayton watches him go. Then he looks down at his own hands, the most skilled pair of hands in Queens, and they are shaking.

26 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CAFETERIA - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 4:44 PM

Marc sits alone at a corner table with a coffee he isn't drinking. Kennerly, with a tray, stops at the table and sits down across from him uninvited.

KENNERLY
(cheerful)
Bullock. (beat) Rough day? I heard Smilley picked the husband. (beat) Blog's going to have that by six.

MARC
(not looking up)
Go away, Kennerly.

KENNERLY
(unwrapping a sandwich)
Hey. I'm being friendly. (beat) We should hang out sometime. (beat) You went to Collegiate, right?

Marc looks up slowly.

KENNERLY
(casually, chewing)
Class of '97? Basketball captain? (beat) I had a cousin at Dalton. We used to come watch you guys play. (beat) Collegiate's pretty expensive for a bus driver's grandson.

A long, still beat. Marc's face shows nothing.

MARC
(pleasantly)
Bullock's a common name, Kennerly.

KENNERLY
(grinning)
Not at Collegiate it isn't. (beat) There was only one.

He picks up his tray and walks away. Marc sits very still. Then he takes out his phone.

SMS, to MAMA: "kennerly knows collegiate. he's working for whitlow."

27 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CHIEF'S OFFICE - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 5:02 PM

Bernie (55) closes the door behind Marc and doesn't even pretend not to listen this time; she stands just outside

it like a guard. Natasha comes around her desk. She doesn't say anything. She takes her son's face in her hands, the way Victor did in the Mercedes.

NATASHA
(quietly)
Esther came by at four forty-five to tell me she's withdrawing her Policy 4.12 form. (beat) So I know.

MARC
(beat)
I asked her, Mama. (beat) I asked her to choose me.

NATASHA
(beat)
I know you did. It's all over your face. (beat) You look exactly like your father did at Founders Library in 1976.

MARC
(beat)
Before you sat down? Or after?

NATASHA
(beat, almost smiling)
Before. (beat) Baby, sometimes people come back, and sometimes they don't. (beat) Your father did. Esther may or may not. (beat) Either way, you will be all right. Because you asked.

Marc nods. She lets go of his face.

MARC
(beat, steadier)
Kennerly knows I went to Collegiate. He has a cousin at Dalton. (beat) Whitlow's using him.

NATASHA
(very still)
I got your text. (beat) Whitlow has a 1997 Collegiate yearbook. Bernie saw it on his desk at two.

MARC
(beat)
Is Bernie spying on him?

NATASHA
(dry)
Bernie has been the executive assistant to four Chiefs of Surgery and two Chiefs of Medicine, including Horace. (beat) Bernie doesn't spy, Marc-Anthony. Bernie notices.

A beat.

NATASHA
(quietly)
Nine days until the board meets. (beat) Go home. Eat something. Let me worry about Horace.

MARC
(beat)
Mama. (beat) I'm not going to let you lose your job over me.

NATASHA
(beat)
I'm not going to lose my job. (beat) And if I did, it wouldn't be over you. (beat) It would be for you. There's a difference.

28 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - ORTHOPEDICS WORKROOM - DAY

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 5:34 PM

A cramped room of X-ray light boxes, bone models and a skeleton wearing a Mardi Gras bead necklace. Camille sits at a computer dictating an op note. Harmony stands in the

doorway.

CAMILLE
(not looking up, into the dictaphone)
"...intramedullary rod, ulna, without complication. End dictation." (looking up) Choir.

HARMONY
(beat)
Friday. Seven-thirty. The Creole place in Fort Greene. (beat) Yes.

Camille sets down the dictaphone. Studies her.

CAMILLE
(beat)
What changed? (beat) At eleven forty you were "thinking about it."

HARMONY
(beat)
At four o'clock somebody I love asked somebody he loves to choose him. (beat) And she didn't. (beat) And I watched his face, and I thought, "Harmony, you have never once in your life asked anybody for anything."

CAMILLE
(gently)
And you thought you'd start with me.

HARMONY
(beat)
I thought I'd start with me. (beat) You just happened to ask first.

Camille grins. Big, warm, Seventh Ward.

CAMILLE
(picking up the dictaphone again)
That's the best yes I've ever gotten, Choir. (beat) Wear something you can dance in.

HARMONY
(alarmed)
Dance?

CAMILLE
(dictating)
"Patient two..."

29 EXT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - AMBULANCE BAY - DAY
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 6:11 PM

The ambulance bay at dusk. And for the first time in five days, the rain has stopped. The pavement steams. Water drips from the overhang. A strip of orange sunset shows under the clouds over Manhattan.

Raven comes out for air in her scrubs and stops, looking up. Arianna comes out behind her with two coffees. She stops beside her. They both look at the sky.

RAVEN
(quietly)
It stopped.

ARIANNA
(beat)
It stopped.

A long beat. Arianna hands her a coffee. Then, staring straight ahead at the sunset, very flat, very brave:

ARIANNA
Ellison. (beat) Do you want to get dinner with me? Tonight? (beat) Like a person asking another person.

Raven looks at her. Then at the dry sky.

RAVEN
(beat, smiling)
Yes.

ARIANNA
(immediately, deadpan, terrified)
Okay. Good. (beat) I didn't make a reservation. I didn't think you'd say yes.

RAVEN
(laughing)
Arianna.

ARIANNA
(beat)
There's a Greek place under my apartment in Astoria. They know me. They'll give us the good table.

RAVEN
(beat)
The bakery? You live above a bakery?

ARIANNA
(beat)
I live above a bakery.

RAVEN
(delighted)
How did I not know that?

ARIANNA
(beat, finally looking at her)
You never asked.

30 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - PEDIATRIC FLOOR - ROOM 4 - NIGHT

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 6:40 PM

Nikki sleeps, her splinted arm propped on a pillow, a cooling fan beside her bed. LaTonya sits in the chair.

Crump (61), bow tie loosened, sits across from her with a folder.

CRUMP
(handing her the folder)
There's a support network for families with CIPA. About three hundred children in the whole country. A mother in Ohio runs it out of her kitchen. (beat) And a pediatric orthopedist at Hospital for Special Surgery who's followed more of these kids than anybody. I called him. He'll see her in November.

LATONYA
(taking it)
Thank you, Doctor.

CRUMP
(beat)
Mrs. Chambers. (beat) You said you have to be her pain. (beat) Every minute. For the rest of her life.

LATONYA
(beat)
I do.

CRUMP
(gently)
You can't. Nobody can. (beat) You can be her mother. You can teach her to check her own feet, her own hands, her own mouth. You can teach her to take her own temperature. (beat) Pain teaches most children. You'll teach her. It's slower. But it works.

LaTonya looks at her sleeping daughter.

LATONYA
(barely)
And who teaches me?

CRUMP
(beat, standing)
The mother in Ohio. (beat) That's why she runs it out of her kitchen.

31 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 7:02 PM

The front door opens. Marc and Harmony come in from the hospital. They stop.

Curtis Lemieux sits on the fantastic couch in his surgical mask, playing "When the Saints Go Marching In" on his trombone, slow, like a dirge, then faster, like a parade. Amond, in the armchair, his feet up, conducts with a pencil, deadpan. From the kitchen comes the smell of red beans and rice. Odile is singing along.

Marc stands in the doorway. Something in his chest that has been clenched since four o'clock lets go, just a little.

AMOND
(not stopping the pencil)
You're late.

MARC
(beat, a small, real smile)
Yeah. (beat) I'm late.

Curtis lowers the trombone.

CURTIS
(through the mask)
Dr. Bullock! Your house has great acoustics. (beat) Mama's making red beans. She found your rice behind all those labels.

ODILE (O.S.)
(from the kitchen)
WHO PUT TURMERIC IN A JAR THAT SAYS "NOT CURRY POWDER"?

HARMONY
(calling back)
Amond's mother!

ODILE (O.S.)
Well, she's right!

Marc sits down on the floor with his back against the couch. Curtis lifts the trombone again and plays "Just a Closer Walk with Thee." Marc closes his eyes.

32 INT. RIVERSIDE DRIVE BROWNSTONE / THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - INTERCUT - NIGHT
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 7:38 PM

Robert, in his study, on the phone. In Hunters Point, Amond picks up in the hallway, the trombone still playing in the living room behind him.

ROBERT
(into the phone)
Dr. Baker. (beat) Is he home?

AMOND
(into the phone, glancing toward the living room)
He's home, sir. On the floor. Curtis Lemieux is playing him a funeral march, and then a parade. (beat) He's listening.

ROBERT
(beat)
Good. (beat) Don't let him run tomorrow morning.

AMOND
(beat)
Sir, I'm on medical leave. I can't stop a six-foot-five man from running.

ROBERT
(dry)
Then go with him. (beat) Ten minutes. Three times a day. Your mother left me a copy of the list.

Amond, in the hallway, closes his eyes in despair.

AMOND
(into the phone)
Of course she did.

END OF ACT FOUR

ACT FIVE

33 INT. MONTY'S ON JACKSON - BAR - NIGHT
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 8:47 PM

A banner over the bar in Gloria's handwriting: "HAPPY 43RD MONTY - THE BAR IS CLOSED (NOT REALLY)." A sheet cake from a bakery on Vernon. Balloons. The whole Queens Grace crowd: Gloria, Big Ray (45), Kendra, Deb Lyons (45), Tee Rollins, Andre Fontaine, the interns. Camille Toussaint in a Saints jersey. Even Graves (52), at the end of the bar with a scotch, looking as if he'd rather be anywhere else and staying anyway.

Monty (43), in a paper birthday crown somebody forced on him, stands behind the bar, pretending to hate every second of it.

GLORIA
(tapping a glass with a knife)
Speech! Speech!

MONTY
(grumbling)
I don't do speeches. I pour.

BIG RAY
(deadpan)
Then somebody do it for him.

Everybody looks around. Marc stands up from the booth. A beat of surprise. Raven glances at Harmony.

MARC
(raising his glass)
To Monty. (beat) Who poured me a drink the night before my first day and never once asked for my last name. (beat) Who poured me five shots in August and then took the bottle away. (beat) Who lent us a sump pump in a nor'easter and asked for nothing but having it back by his birthday. (beat) It's back, Monty.

Laughter.

MARC
(beat)
You told me on Saturday to go save her boat and not to go save her. (beat) I listened to half of that. (beat) The boat floats. (beat) To Monty. Forty-three. The only man in Queens who knows everything and repeats nothing.

EVERYONE
To Monty!

Glasses clink. Monty looks at Marc across the bar for a long beat. He nods once. Then he takes off the paper crown, sets it on the bar and pours Marc a club soda with lime without being asked.

34 INT. MONTY'S ON JACKSON - BAR - NIGHT
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 9:36 PM

The party has thinned. Marc sits at the end of the bar with his club soda. Monty wipes the counter in front of him.

MONTY
(not looking up)
You asked her.

MARC
(beat)
How do you...?

MONTY
(tapping his ear)
Bar. (beat) Also, Gloria.

MARC
(beat)
I asked her. (beat) She said she's going to try with him.

MONTY
(beat)
Then you did the thing. (beat) That's all a man can do, son. Ask, and then live with the answer. (beat) Most men don't even get to the asking. They sit at the end of my bar for twenty years wondering what she'd have said.

MARC
(beat)
Is that what happened to you?

Monty stops wiping. He looks at the photo taped to his register: a younger Monty with a woman in a 1980s perm, laughing, on the Coney Island boardwalk.

MONTY
(beat)
Yvonne. 1987. (beat) I never asked. (beat) She married a fireman from Bay Ridge. Three kids. (beat) Every year on her birthday I put on the record she liked, and I don't tell anybody why.

MARC
(quietly)
Monty.

MONTY
(going back to wiping)
You asked, Doc. (beat) Twenty years from now, you won't be sitting at the end of somebody's bar wondering. (beat) Whatever she does with it.

35 INT. THE CLARENCE - CABIN - NIGHT
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 9:51 PM

Esther, alone on the boat, packs an overnight bag. Not everything. Just enough for a few nights at Clayton's. She opens the galley drawer. Inside: the ring. And an empty space where the MiniDV tape used to be.

She takes out the ring and holds it. Gold, with a single diamond. She looks at it for a long moment.

She puts it on her left hand. On her finger, not a chain.

She looks at her hand. Then at the Christmas lights on the boom outside the porthole. The lights she turned off on the night Marc stayed.

She switches them on. Then off again. She picks up her bag and climbs the companionway steps.

36 INT. NATASHA AND ROBERT'S BROWNSTONE - RIVERSIDE DRIVE - STUDY - NIGHT
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 10:14 PM

Natasha at the desk on the phone, in reading glasses. Robert in the doorway.

NATASHA
(into the phone)
No, Daddy. Don't come. (beat) Because he doesn't need his grandfather tonight. He needs his house. (beat) His roommates. A man with a trombone. (beat) Yes, a trombone. (beat) I'll tell him. Good night.

She hangs up. Takes off her glasses.

ROBERT
(quietly)
He asked her?

NATASHA
(beat)
He asked her. (beat) On the roof. (beat) She said no.

Robert comes in and sits on the edge of the desk. He's quiet a long moment.

ROBERT
(finally)
He asked. (beat) That's my boy. (beat) It took me three weeks of sulking in Founders Library before I could even say your name, Tasha. (beat) He asked on the day.

NATASHA
(beat)
And Horace has his high school yearbook.

ROBERT
(beat)
Then Horace knows the boy was captain of the basketball team and wrote "Bullock is a common name" under his own senior picture. (beat) Let him bring that to the board.

37 INT. ELXA AND RUSSELL'S HOUSE - ST. ALBANS - BEDROOM - NIGHT

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 10:29 PM

Elxa (28), twenty-three weeks, lies on her side in bed with a pregnancy pillow the size of a canoe. Russell (30) sits up beside her grading chemistry labs.

ELXA
(quietly)
He asked her.

RUSSELL
(putting down his pen)
On the roof?

ELXA
On the roof. (beat) He did it like himself, not like a Bullock. Harmony told me. (beat) She said no.

RUSSELL
(beat)
Damn. (beat) Is he okay?

ELXA
(beat)
A man with a trombone is playing him Mahalia Jackson on his living room floor. (beat) He'll be okay.

Russell lies back down and puts his hand on her belly. A kick. He smiles.

RUSSELL
(softly)
I'd have asked you on a roof.

ELXA
(beat)
You asked me at a Popeyes on Merrick Boulevard.

RUSSELL
(beat)
It had a roof.

38 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CHIEF OF MEDICINE'S OFFICE - NIGHT
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 10:42 PM

Whitlow's banker's lamp. The Collegiate yearbook open on the desk to Marc's senior portrait. Beside it, the CV binder open to Robert's page, and the loading dock log with its circle. Whitlow holds the phone to his ear.

WHITLOW
(into the phone, warmly)
Judge Kittredge. Horace Whitlow. I apologize for the hour. (beat) Yes. The twentieth. (beat) I wonder if you'd let me buy you lunch on Monday at the Harvard Club. (beat) I've found something I think you'll want to see before you vote. (beat) A family photograph, of sorts.

He listens. He smiles.

WHITLOW
(into the phone)
Wonderful. Monday at one.

He hangs up. He looks at the portrait: the grinning eighteen-year-old in the navy blazer. "Bullock is a common name."

WHITLOW
(softly, to the photograph)
Your grandfather turned me down in a library, young man. (beat) Let's see what he does in a boardroom.

END OF ACT FIVE

TAG

39 EXT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - STOOP - NIGHT
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 11:31 PM

The first dry night in five days. Stars, faintly, over Queens. Marc sits on the stoop. Amond sits beside him on a cushion Harmony put out, against Harriet's typed instructions.

AMOND
(staring at the street)
She chose him.

MARC
(beat)
She chose to try.

AMOND
(beat)
Same thing, said nicer. (beat)
Her loss.

Marc laughs. A real one. It surprises both of them.

Down the block, two figures walk up 49th Avenue from the 7 train: Raven and Arianna, back from dinner in Astoria. They're holding hands. They see Marc and Amond on the stoop and let go, fast.

MARC
(calling, gently)
Don't stop on my account.

A beat. Raven looks at Arianna. Arianna looks at the sidewalk. Then Raven takes Arianna's hand again, deliberately, and they walk up the steps past the boys like that.

ARIANNA
(passing Amond, deadpan)
Not a word, Baker.

AMOND
(deadpan)
I wasn't going to say anything. (beat) I was going to write it down.

The girls go inside, laughing. Harmony comes out with three cups of tea and sits down on Marc's other side.

HARMONY
(handing them out)
Friday. (beat) I said yes. To Camille.

MARC
(looking at her, a slow smile)
Double-O.

HARMONY
(beat)
You asked. (beat) So I asked myself.

Marc puts his arm around her shoulders. She leans in. Amond sips his tea and pretends not to notice anything.

MARC (V.O.)
You don't get to choose most things.

40 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - MARC'S BEDROOM - NIGHT
TUESDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2005 - 11:52 PM

Marc's room. He opens the top drawer of his dresser. Inside: the MiniDV tape. "FOR MARC." Forty-one seconds.

MARC (V.O.)
You don't get to choose who chooses you.

He picks it up. Holds it. He doesn't play it. He puts it back in the drawer, under a folded Howard sweatshirt, and closes the drawer.

MARC (V.O.)
But you get to choose whether you ask. (beat) And you get to choose who you are the morning after.

He turns off the light.

MARC (V.O.)
I choose the guy who asked.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE

Media Companion: Episode 2x05

Off-screen media around the episode, in chronological order. Not counted in page length (MA-009 §5).

ASSOCIATED PRESS: "ANGELS ELIMINATE YANKEES IN GAME 5"

Monday, October 10, 2005

"ANAHEIM, Calif. (AP) -- The Los Angeles Angels beat the New York Yankees 5-3 on Monday night to win their American League division series in five games, ending another Yankees season without a championship..."

QueensGraceConfidential (Blogger)

Tuesday, October 11, 2005, 6:02 PM

"It's official. Day 30. Boston is staying with Boston. Our roof spy (we have a roof spy now) says Dr. X went up at 4:00, said something nobody could hear, and came down at 4:06 with the face of a man who'd asked a question and gotten an answer. We're not making jokes tonight. We're just saying: he asked. Most people never do. Also, the Kennerly hearing: probation. Chief of Medicine Whitlow testified FOR him, which is... a choice." Comments (881).

GME Committee: hearing summary (Bassett)

Tuesday, October 11, 2005

"RE: Dr. Bryce Kennerly (PGY-1). Finding: conduct unbecoming and harassment of a colleague (distribution of approximately 300 copies of a personal image, September 2005). Sanction: probation through June 30, 2006; mandatory professionalism training; letter to file. Note: Dr. H. Whitlow addressed the committee unsolicited. Dr. L. Graves, chair, so noted."

SMS, Motorola RAZR (Esther Smilley to Marc-Anthony Bullock)

Tuesday, October 11, 2005, 5:31 AM

Esther: "roof at 4? day 30. i want you to hear it from me first. like i promised."

SMS, Motorola RAZR (Marc-Anthony Bullock to Natasha Donohue)

Tuesday, October 11, 2005, 4:47 PM

Marc: "kennerly knows collegiate. he's working for whitlow."

Natasha: "My office. Now."

Collegiate School yearbook, 1997 (senior page)

1997

"MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK. Varsity Basketball (Capt.). Debate. Model U.N. 'Bullock is a common name.' -- Princeton? Howard. Definitely Howard."

SMS, Motorola RAZR (Raven Ellison to Harmony Divine)

Tuesday, October 11, 2005, 6:14 PM

Raven: "it stopped raining"

Raven: "she asked again"

Raven: "i said yes"

Harmony: "!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

Harmony: "i said yes too. friday. camille"

Raven: "HARMONY DIVINE"

Continuity Sheet: Episode 2x05

New Canon Established

- **Day 30 (Tuesday, October 11, 2005): Esther chooses to stay married to Clayton** and make a real try. This is the counterpart of Derek choosing Addison. She told Marc first on the roof at 4:00 PM, as promised, and told him she slept with Clayton on October 8. Her conditions for Clayton: weekly sessions with Dr. Greenidge, no secrets ('If Malcolm calls you, I know that day'), she stays 'Dr. Smilley' at work, and she stays on the boat until she's ready. She now wears the ring on her finger and withdrew her Policy 4.12 form.
- **Marc's 'Choose me' speech** on the roof is the counterpart of Meredith's 'pick me, choose me, love me.' Its key lines: 'not yet is sometimes the polite word for no' (Victor), 'the one who told you the truth sober,' and 'Choose me.' Marc: 'Be happy, Es. Or come tell me if you're not.' To Clayton: 'Be good to her... Then you and I won't ever have a problem.' To Monty: 'I choose the guy who asked.'
- **Harmony said yes to Camille**: dinner Friday, October 14, 7:30 PM, at a Creole restaurant in Fort Greene ('wear something you can dance in'). 'I thought I'd start with me.' **Raven and Arianna's first date** was October 11 at the Greek restaurant under Arianna's apartment (she lives above a Greek bakery on 30th Avenue, Astoria). They came home holding hands, and Marc, Amond and Harmony know.
- **Whitlow has Marc's 1997 Collegiate yearbook** ('Bullock is a common name,' Basketball captain), from his godson's older brother. Kennerly, with a cousin at Dalton, confronted Marc: 'Not at Collegiate it isn't.' Collegiate tuition in 1997 was $17,900. **Whitlow has a lunch with Judge Kittredge** at the Harvard Club, Monday, October 17, 1:00 PM: 'a family photograph, of sorts.' Bernie saw the yearbook on his desk. Robert: 'Let him bring that to the board.'
- **Kennerly hearing outcome:** probation through June 30, 2006, professionalism training and a letter to file. Whitlow testified unsolicited, and Graves noted it on the record. Esther compared the copies to her father's crime-scene photos in the 1987 Boston Globe.
- **Rev. Isaac Ashworth** (an undecided trustee) toured the Bridge Fund pharmacy: 312 children served since September 8. Dorian asked him to thank God for the dog. 'Horace Whitlow asked me yesterday. He didn't bring a little boy.'
- **Harriet and Solomon returned to Los Angeles** on October 11. Amond agreed to call on Sundays. Harriet: 'Your father would have been so proud of you, it would have been unbearable.' Amond thanked Solomon for the photo. Robert has a copy of Harriet's list. Amond watched a mitral repair from the gallery against orders, and Big Ray told Robert.
- **Curtis Lemieux** was discharged October 10. He and Odile played trombone and cooked red beans at 49th Avenue ('Just a Closer Walk with Thee').
- **Monty's 43rd birthday** party was October 11 at Monty's. Marc gave the toast. **New canon:** Monty never asked out Yvonne in 1987; she married a Bay Ridge firefighter. Gloria has had two husbands. Elxa got engaged to Russell at a Popeyes on Merrick Boulevard. Marc took Simone Pettigrew to the Collegiate spring formal in 10th grade.

- **Booker Haines** is pain-free 8 days after surgery and shaved both sides of his face for the first time since 1999. Mae kissed his right cheek.

Knowledge Tracker (as of October 11, 2005)

Secret	Who knows	New pressure
Marc is Natasha and Robert's son	Family, Bernie, Graves, Gloria, Mrs. Truitt, Amond, Big Ray, Arianna, Esther	**Whitlow has the yearbook** and is meeting Kittredge on October 17; Kennerly knows about Collegiate; Clayton, Raven and Harmony suspect
Marc and Victor	Same	Raven and Harmony saw Victor on October 8
Esther and Clayton reconciling	Public (the blog)	-
Raven and Arianna dating	Marc, Amond, Harmony	-
Harmony and Camille's date	Raven, Marc, Amond	-

Patient Registry

Patient	DOB / age	Diagnosis	Procedure / surgeon	Outcome
Nikki Chambers	8/2/1998 (7)	Congenital insensitivity to pain with anhidrosis (CIPA); open radius and ulna fracture about 18 h old; hyperthermia 105.4; febrile seizure	Active cooling, lorazepam; I&D;, radial ORIF, ulnar IM rod (Camille; Crump; Harmony, Marc)	Afebrile; HSS follow-up in November; CIPA family network
Mitral patient	-	P2 prolapse	Triangular resection repair (Robert)	Uncomplicated
Booker Haines	5/16/1941 (64)	Post-MVD, day 8	Clinic (Esther)	Pain-free

New Characters

- **Nikki Chambers** (b. August 2, 1998) and **LaTonya Chambers** (b. January 15, 1974), a school bus driver.
- **Rev. Isaac Ashworth** (b. March 30, 1937), QGH trustee and pastor of Greater Bethel Baptist Church, St. Albans (a swing vote).

Real-World Accuracy Notes

- The Angels eliminated the Yankees 5-3 in ALDS Game 5 on October 10, 2005. The October 2005 rains eased around October 11-12. Collegiate School is on the Upper West Side, and Dalton is on the Upper East Side.
- Medicine: CIPA (HSAN type IV, an NTRK1 mutation) causes absent pain and anhidrosis, with hyperthermia, self-mutilation (tongue injuries in infancy), unnoticed fractures and Charcot joints. Patients still need general anesthesia because of autonomic responses. An open fracture needs urgent irrigation and debridement, antibiotics and fixation. Fever in anhidrosis needs external cooling, since antipyretics are of limited help. Hospital for Special Surgery is in

Manhattan.